

… fabriquer mes logarithmes comme on fabrique des épingles.

… to manufacture my logarithms as one manufactures pins.

Gaspard de Prony, *Notice sur les grandes tables logarithmiques…*, 1824. English: lecturer

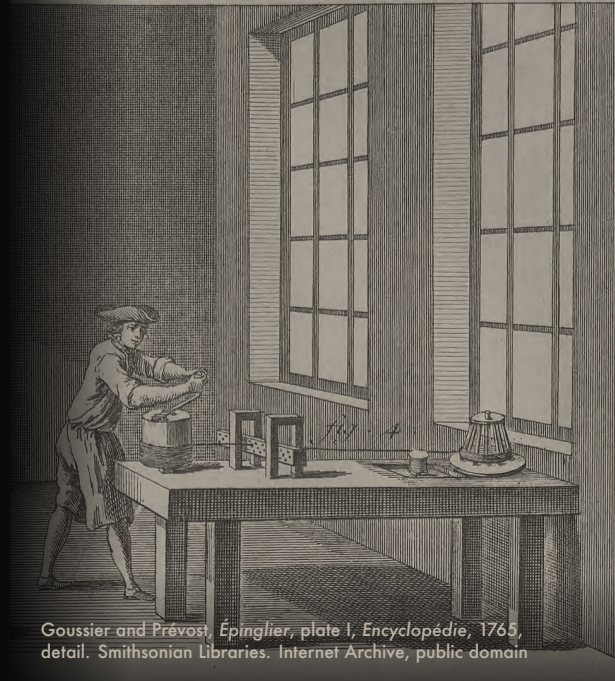
Goussier and Defehrt, *Épinglier*, plate II, *Encyclopédie*, 1765, detail. Smithsonian Libraries. Internet Archive, public domain

Adam Smith

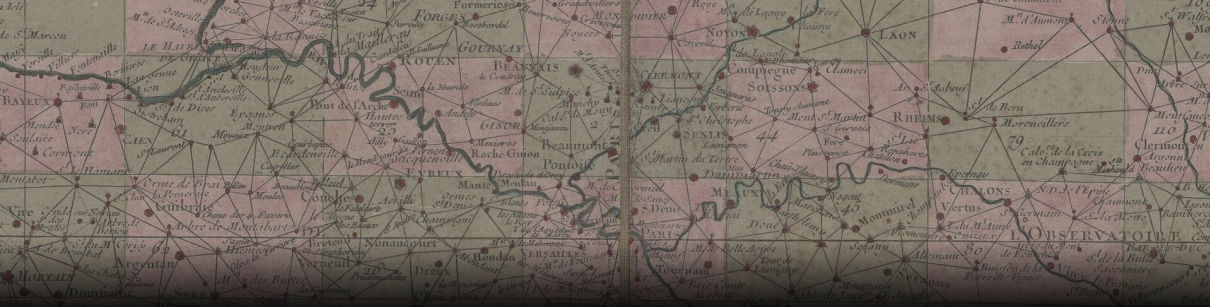
1723 to 1790

"One man draws out the wire; another straights it; a third cuts it; a fourth points it; a fifth grinds it at the top for receiving the head… Those ten persons, therefore, could make among them upwards of forty-eight thousand pins in a day."

Adam Smith, *The Wealth of Nations*, 1776, Book I, chapter 1



Goussier and Prévost, *Épinglier*, plate I, *Encyclopédie*, 1765, detail. Smithsonian Libraries. Internet Archive, public domain



Every parcel in France

The French Revolution, 1790 to 1793

The Revolution taxes land, so the area of every parcel has to be computed. Land is measured in triangles, computed with tables of logarithms.

In 1793 Gaspard de Prony, director of the Bureau du cadastre in Paris, is ordered to compute new tables.

Maraldi and Cassini de Thury, map of the principal triangles of France, 1744, detail. BnF. Wikimedia Commons, public domain

Three tiers

Bureau du cadastre, 1793 to 1796

Five or six mathematicians choose the formulas and pass them down.

Seven or eight analysts turn them into the first values of each page and pass the pages down.

About twenty computers fill in each page, using only additions and subtractions.



The computers of the Harvard College Observatory, about 1890.
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Weekend 2

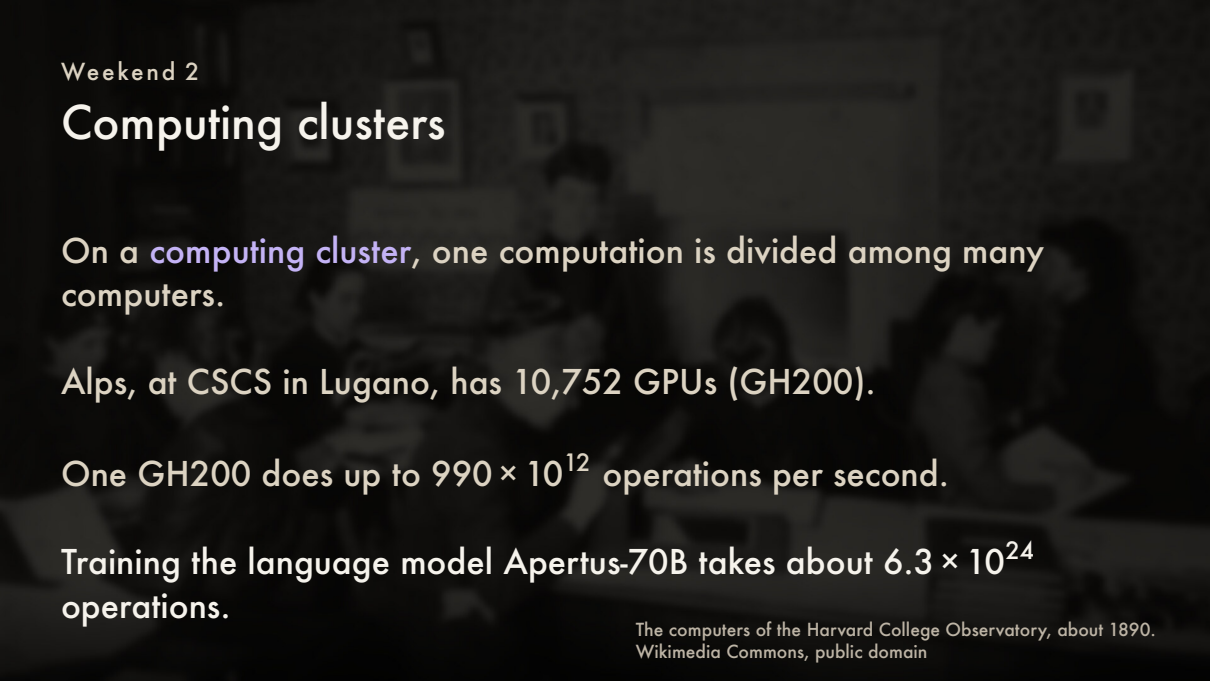
Computing clusters

On a computing cluster, one computation is divided among many computers.

Alps, at CSCS in Lugano, has 10,752 GPUs (GH200).

One GH200 does up to 990×10^{12} operations per second.

Training the language model Apertus-70B takes about 6.3×10^{24} operations.



The computers of the Harvard College Observatory, about 1890.
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